Trust is the new checkout

How Visa can turn AI shopping agents from a pilot into a habit.

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With real money on the line, what would make people let an AI agent pay for them?

Visa has built the rails for AI agents to pay. I looked at what would get people to **actually use them**, and how Visa's Data & AI team can help.

The rails are built. *Trust* is what's missing.

What's happening

AI agents have started buying for people.

- **$190B to $385B** of US spending through agents by 2030 (Morgan Stanley)
- **10% to 20%** of US e-commerce
- Visa, Mastercard, OpenAI and Google all let agents pay

What I found

Modest revenue, big position.

- About **$99B** of 2030 agent spending on Visa
- Roughly **$278M** net revenue, under 1% of today's (illustrative)
- Only **6%** trust an AI to buy without checking in (Worldpay)

What I recommend

Make control visible.

- Agent limits and approvals inside banking apps
- Start with baskets **under $100**
- A clear fix for agent mistakes

In about a year, AI agents went from *suggesting* products to *paying* for them

Apr 2025

Visa Intelligent Commerce

Agent-specific card tokens, passkeys and spending limits

Sep 2025

OpenAI Instant Checkout

Buy inside ChatGPT, built with Stripe on the Agentic Commerce Protocol

Sep 2025

Google AP2

A protocol for proving an agent is allowed to pay

Oct 2025

Visa Trusted Agent Protocol

With Cloudflare, so merchants can tell good agents from bots

Apr 2026

Intelligent Commerce Connect

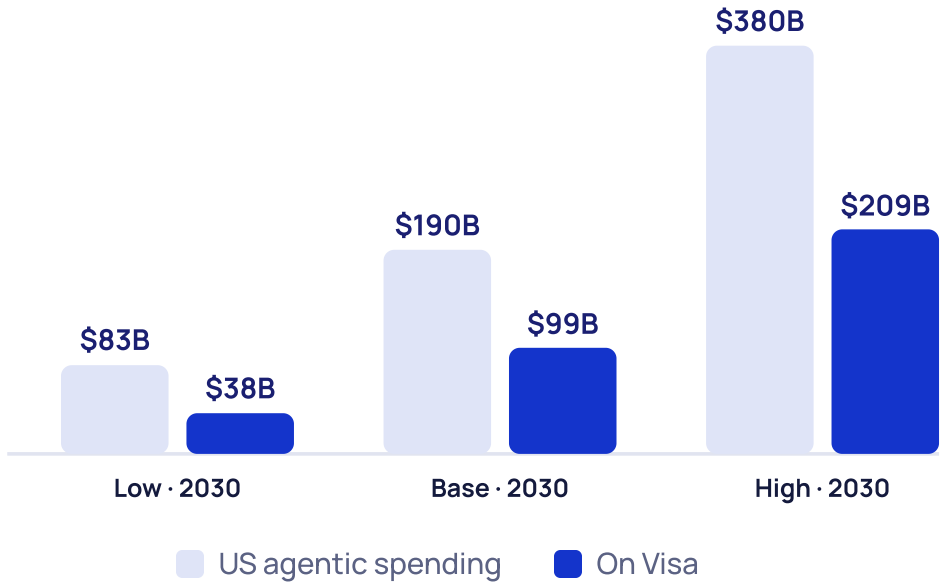
One on-ramp that supports the major agent protocols

4,700%+

Growth in AI-driven visits to US retail sites over one year, reported by Visa in October 2025. That counts traffic, not completed purchases, but it shows agents are already out shopping. Every major player now has a payment protocol, so **the rails are no longer the hard part**.

Gold dots are Visa launches. Sources: Visa newsroom, OpenAI, Google, partner releases.

By 2030, about *$190B* of US spending could run through AI agents. Roughly half of it on Visa.



US e-commerce in 2030 — **$1.65T**
$1.23T in 2025 (Census), grown 6% a year

× 11.5% bought through AI agents — **$190B**
Matches Morgan Stanley's 2030 base case

× 85% paid with card credentials — **$161B**
My assumption; the rest goes to bank transfers and other rails

× 61% on Visa — **$99B**
Visa's share of US card spending in 2024 (Nilson, Feb 2025), assumed to hold for card-paid agent spending

Low: slow adoption
5% of e-commerce through agents, 75% on cards

Base: most likely case
11.5% through agents, 85% on cards

High: fast adoption
23% through agents (Morgan Stanley bull case), 90% on cards

All three are 2030 projections. Sources: US Census Bureau, Q4 2025 e-commerce; Morgan Stanley, Nov 2025; Nilson Report, 2024. Full model in the Excel file.

Being the default is what counts.



Illustrative Visa net revenue from US agent spending, 2030

0.3% to 1.5%

of Visa's FY2025 net revenue ($40.0B), across all three scenarios

$46M a year

is what 10 points of share are worth in the base case. If Visa's share of card-paid agent spending slipped from **61% to 51%**, it would lose about $46M a year ($161B × 10% × 0.28% net revenue yield).

The real risk

is position. An agent pays with whichever card it holds, for every purchase it makes. Losing that slot costs more than any one year's revenue.

Illustrative: assumes Visa's blended FY2025 yield (0.28% of payments volume) applies to agent spending. At half or double it, the base case is $139M to $556M.

Few people trust an agent with open-ended spending. *Limits could change that.*



6% would let AI buy automatically without checking in

Worldpay, 8 countries, 2025

55% are uncomfortable with agents buying for them

Riskified, US and UK, Q1 2026

51% say the AI platform should be responsible for unauthorized or mistaken agent purchases

Riskified, Q1 2026

69% would let an agent spend up to $100 on groceries and essentials

Global Payments, 2026

Comfort looks higher when the purchase is small, routine and capped.

These surveys asked different people different questions, so they don't prove it on their own. Together they point to a hypothesis: **limits make agents easier to trust**. The pilot is built to test it.

Three ways Visa could play

Option	Builds shopper trust	Fits Visa's partners	Uses Visa's data	Speed to impact
A. Launch a Visa shopping agent Compete for the shopper directly	◐	○	◐	○
B. Keep widening the rails More protocols and partners. Needed, and already underway	○	●	◐	●
C. Make control visible to shoppers Limits, approvals and fixes where people manage money RECOMMENDED	●	●	●	◐

● Strong ◐ Partial ○ Weak Option A competes with the issuers and AI platforms Visa depends on.

Put the controls *where people already manage their money*

Step 1

An "Agents" screen in issuers' apps

- **Visa provides** the design and APIs, built on its agent tokens and passkeys
- **Issuers add** one screen to their app
- **Shoppers get** every agent in one place, with limits and one-tap off

The controls exist in Visa's network. **Shoppers just can't see them yet.**

Step 2

Start with the everyday basket

- Groceries and household refills
- Orders under $100

69% would let an agent spend up to $100 on essentials (Global Payments, 2026).

Step 3

A clear fix when an agent gets it wrong

- One dispute path for agent purchases
- Visa's record shows what the agent was allowed to buy

About half say the AI platform should answer for unauthorized or mistaken purchases (Riskified, 2026).

A 90-day pilot with *four numbers* to watch

Enrollment

Share of cardholders who add an agent after seeing the controls screen

Repeat use

Share who make a second agent purchase within 30 days.

The real test of trust

Hands-off rate

Purchases completed inside the limit with no manual approval needed

Dispute rate

At or below regular online card purchases, or the controls aren't working

WHO	WHAT	DECISION
2 digital-first issuers ship the screen to a test group of cardholders, with 1 agent partner	Groceries and household refills, under $100	Scale if repeat use grows and disputes stay low

What could go wrong

Issuers move slowly

Banking app changes take time.

Test: start with two digital-first issuers and a shared design Visa provides.

Controls add friction

Too many prompts and people give up.

Test: smart default limits that need no setup, approvals only above the limit.

Agents skip cards

Bank transfers or stablecoins could win the agent slot.

Test: keep supporting every protocol through Intelligent Commerce Connect.

Privacy concerns

Sharing purchase data with agents can feel invasive.

Test: consent-first sharing, written with the Chief Privacy Officer, explained in plain words.

Where the numbers come from

US e-commerce, 2025
US Census Bureau, Quarterly Retail E-Commerce, Q4 2025: $1,233.7B

Visa card share
Nilson Report, Feb 2025: Visa 61.1% of US card spending in 2024

Consumer trust
Worldpay (2025), Riskified (Q1 2026), Global Payments (2026)

Visa financials
Visa FY2025 Form 10-K: $40.0B net revenue, $14.2T payments volume

Agentic forecast
Morgan Stanley, reported Nov 2025: ~$190B base, ~$385B bull, 2030

Visa agentic products
Visa newsroom: Intelligent Commerce (2025), Trusted Agent Protocol (2025), Intelligent Commerce Connect (2026)

Method: 2030 e-commerce × share bought through agents × share paid by card × Visa's card share × net revenue yield, in three scenarios. Every input and formula is in the Excel model. The consumer surveys asked different questions, so I compare them side by side and don't merge them into one number.